

how to get started. They often think there are many challenges to get a server up and running.

“But by opting out of that decision making, they are also opting for proprietary software. We are trying to show them various ways to do it differently. Do it on Raspberry Pi, a cheap server, or even on a wireless router. We show the examples, and people can choose the place where they want to host it,” he explains.

“If others control all this software, then they control the software which runs on it, and the data which resides on it. They control the way it goes out to others, and to whom. That is not what the internet was meant to be. It was a place where we all run our own space, and run it in a truly federated manner,” he notes.

The FOSS journey

As a student, in 1997-98, Abhas recalls constantly seeking new things to do with his computer. This led to experimentation with other operating systems (OSs) such as OS2 and Windows NT. During this time, he bought a book to learn about Linux, which everyone was talking about. He taught himself a “little bit of LaTeX” too. “Then, there was no looking back,” he remembers.

FOSS, he believes, is a serious option for youngsters to generate employment and acquire valuable skills. He points to the bigger picture: “When you feel that pressure is building up in the place you’re in right now, you will make a different choice. Free software is one of the best ways to do that. Using free software can often be the best way to solve a problem.”

Biggest challenges

What does Abhas see as the biggest challenges before FOSS (Free and Open Source Software) or FLOSS (Libre, too) software in India today?

He says, “I feel that, in general, GNU/Linux usage is decreasing, and that is a concerning trend. For a lot of

Some of the sites worth visiting, related to Abhas’ work:

1. Hardware solutions that don’t compromise your privacy, freedom, opportunity to learn, do things on your own: <https://mostlyharmless.io>
2. Ethical and hackable products: <https://libretech.shop>
3. Online support; discourse forum: <https://ask.libre.support>
4. What is a free software business: where you combine respect for your users’ freedom with your choice of building a business: <https://freesoftware.business>
5. Commemorating 20 years of DeepRoot GNU/Linux: <https://20.deeproot.in>
6. ActivityPub: <https://sovrان.me>
7. Hacks.Wiki (an experiment to organise quick hacks, notes, bookmarks and tools into an easy-to-build-and-maintain ‘digital garden’): <https://hacks.wiki/About/>
8. Sovran Video powered by PeerTube, an ActivityPub-federated video streaming platform using P2P directly in your web browser: <https://sovrان.video>
9. Sovran Photos: <https://sovrان.photos/@abhas>
10. Keypad: <https://sovrان.dev/mh/vckyb6/> / <https://libretech.shop/product/kids-klack> (Abhas built this to help his daughter attend online school classes during Covid)
11. Writings: <https://abhas.io>

younger people, it is entirely normal to run free software on proprietary operating systems or alongside a mix of proprietary software.”

Apart from desktop operating systems, there are other systems involved too that are proprietary. A lot of free software is developed around GitHub, a proprietary version control system and community operated by Microsoft. There are many more such online proprietary ecosystems. “For some reason, we no longer feel uncomfortable about mixing proprietary and free software in this way,” he argues.

If you ask a group of students how they would build an online group for collaboration, the most popular responses are: WhatsApp, Telegram, Discord, etc — all proprietary systems. “The first tools of choice are not email, mailing lists, matrix or something else

that is free software and can be self-hosted and maintained by ourselves. This blurring of the line between free and proprietary software is what is worrisome,” he adds.

Several things have disappeared from the common ‘FLOSS discourse’ in India. No one really talks about localisation (Indic language solutions in FOSS) anymore. Or the freedom to compute freely and privately. Or even having fun, Abhas says, with a tinge of regret. As he puts it: “Lest we forget, Torvalds wrote the Linux kernel ‘just for fun’ (as goes the title of his autobiography). He wanted to understand how the 80386 CPU from Intel worked, and he decided to write an operating system kernel for that. The rest is history... but it all started with the need to have a certain sort of fun. And I feel that this too is missing.” 

 By: Frederick Noronha

The author is a Goa-based freelance journalist, who has been tracking FOSS, Creative Commons and the Wikipedia issues for a long time.